



September 27, 2023

Contact: queerjoyatua@gmail.com

OFFICIAL STATEMENT REGARDING UPCOMING “LIVE FREE TOUR” AT UNIVERSITY AT ALBANY FEATURING QUEERPHOBIC COMMENTATOR CANDACE OWENS

From its very creation, Queer Joy UA has aimed to prioritize the safety and well being of the Queer and Trans population on campus. It comes to us with disturbance but ultimately as no surprise that UAlbany has rented out the CC Ballroom to Turning Point USA for their ‘Live Free Tour’ featuring Candace Owens, who has built her career around racist and queerphobic rhetoric. Queer Joy UA wholeheartedly denounces this event.

Queer Joy UA urges caution to our Queer and Trans siblings, and especially students of color, who may be inclined to protest this event. While we stand in solidarity with anyone who does choose to attend this event in protest, we urge our community to take care of ourselves first and foremost and evaluate the risks that attending this event may pose. Given that UAlbany failed to stand with marginalized students as their images were being blasted on social media and used in right-wing news outlets in the wake of student protests last semester, leading to violent threats and harassment, and given how high profile Candace Owens is as a public figure, we urge students to take care of themselves, and to consider attending alternative actions to avoid putting themselves in a traumatic position. Turning Point USA notes that the ‘audience will be video recorded’ and that ‘video and audio surveillance will be in use,’ and this compounded with the personal and identifiable information they are requiring attendees to provide will lead to harassment from Turning Point USA’s national hateful base.

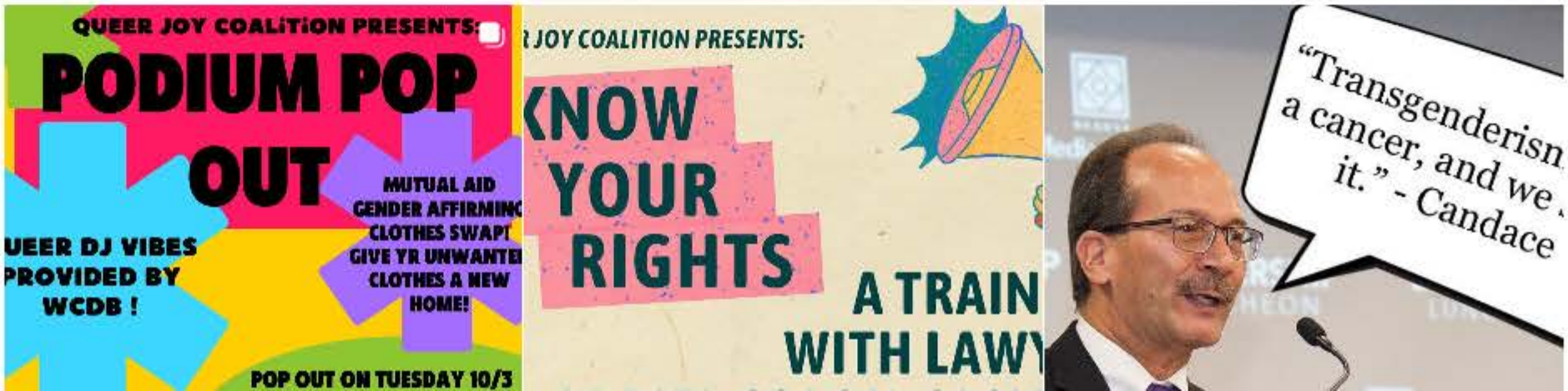


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UAlbany is creating a space where Turning Point USA can surveil its marginalized students and collect personal identifiable information to directly lead to further harassment. Our concerns are based on our 4th amendment rights to our protections against search and seizure by the government. Our objections are based on the safety and security of students on campus. Turning Point USA has a history of distributing this information online which led in the past to students receiving death threats and threats of violence. Turning Point USA is coming to campus with the express purpose of creating a hostile educational environment and to make money off of the reactions of students they deliberately antagonize, and the University is facilitating that. We are concerned that UAlbany is a hostile educational environment. **UAlbany does not have to allow this event to go forward given the risks this event poses to student health and safety.**

Marginalized students, including students of color and Trans and Queer students, deserve to feel safe on this campus. **UAlbany has once again failed to meet their affirmative obligation to protect marginalized students** by allowing Turning Point USA to require sensitive and private information, including their full name, email, phone number (and to verify their phone number), and zip code to simply register for this event. To gain entry to the event, students must show a valid form of ID that matches the information on their ticket. Turning Point USA is a national organization that is known for their hateful and harmful rhetoric, and by permitting their collection of students' identifiable information as a prerequisite to attend this event, **UAlbany is subjecting marginalized students to national hate and harassment.**

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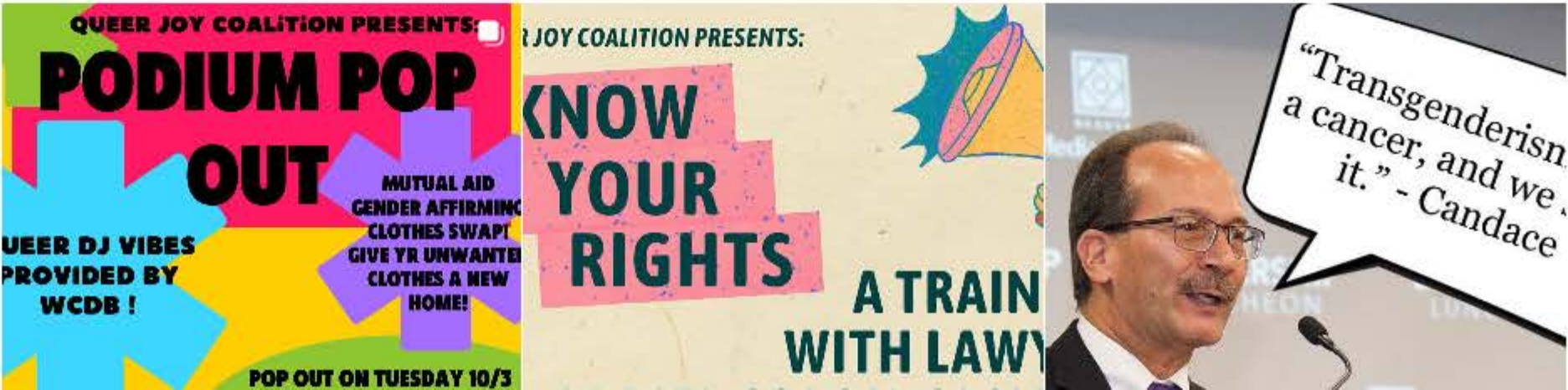
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UAlbany is failing to protect its marginalized students once again, and does not have to allow the Live Free Tour event on October 3 to go forward given the risks this event poses to students' health and safety. Queer Joy UA urges caution to our Queer and Trans siblings, and especially students of color, who may be inclined to attend the Live Free Tour in protest. We encourage students to take care of themselves first and foremost, and to consider attending alternative events Queer Joy UA is hosting, including a Podium Pop-Out celebration of queer joy. We also encourage students to stop by the Queer Community Safety Zone in the GSRC, and the Common Council meeting to speak out against a resolution intended to enforce the



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